



Root causes

India's youth crisis is about the absence of jobs, not just examination reform

It has been a few weeks since the youth agitation forced the resignation of then Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. The government conceded the students’ demands for examination reform, which found an echo in the Prime Minister’s Independence Day address, when he announced free online coaching for competitive examinations using India’s digital public infrastructure. MoSPI’s survey data bears out why this would be welcome to students – private coaching costs 16% of what an Indian family spends on a child’s education, against 12.5% in 2018, and nearly a quarter of that budget by the higher secondary years which is when the student prepares for competitive exams. Cheaper coaching is of limited value as quality professional education remains confined to a handful of institutions. For instance, over 22 lakh candidates appeared in this year’s medical entrance exam for about 1.4 lakh undergraduate seats with fewer than 10,000 of them at the top 50 colleges. The situation is similar to the Joint Entrance Examination for engineering colleges. That is perhaps why, for the first time since the All India Survey on Higher Education began in 2011, undergraduate enrolment fell by 93,322 in 2023-24, particularly among young men. The fall was the sharpest in Uttar Pradesh, where *The Hindu’s* analysis found undergraduate enrolment down 1.53 lakh even as diploma enrolment rose 1.38 lakh. An analysis of Periodic Labour Force Survey unit-level data found that of every 100 graduates aged 15 to 29 in 2025, only 26 were in regular salaried employment, and just four had a salaried job with a contract and social security. The youth employment crisis therefore has two ends – in the preparation for jobs, and in jobs themselves. Mere free coaching would address neither.

The structural problems in the Indian economy, despite the government’s touting of 6%-6.5% growth, are now too obvious to ignore. Manufacturing, the job sector best placed to absorb India’s college graduates, remains at around a sixth of gross value added, nowhere near the quarter of the economy the government has long promised. Meanwhile, the private sector has been retreating from its task as corporate investment has fallen from 17.3% of GDP in 2007-08 to 10.3% in 2024-25, unmoved by the cut in corporate tax from 30% to 22% in 2019. The steps required of the Union government are clear: public investment in industrial capacity, support for industry disciplined by export performance rather than domestic protection, and tempering a regulatory and enforcement zeal that seems to selectively target enterprises, affecting the jobs-catering medium-sized companies in particular. This route has a better chance of delivering jobs for the youth at the scale needed and as countries such as Vietnam have shown.

Escape velocity

India's space sector must focus on reliability and regular launches

For much of the 20th century, a rocket tearing a white seam through the sky did for India roughly what football did for Argentina and Brazil. Nations shut out of the councils where economic and strategic weight was measured found, in a game of European origin, an arena where their poverty did not disqualify them. Mastery was open to anyone with nerve and skill. Space was other things but also India’s football. A famished, newly independent republic that could barely feed itself nevertheless chose to gamble on rockets and atomic piles – an expensive bet on a future it could not yet see. In that era of a controlled economy and state broadcaster monopoly, a launcher rising was its own justification. The utility of its payload was secondary, in the eyes of the masses, to the veneer of technological competency. Today, rockets and satellites are no longer emblems; they are the plumbing of the information age, the unglamorous scaffolding beneath navigation, banking, weather and war. On the third National Space Day – the anniversary of Chandrayaan-3’s touchdown in the lunar south polar region – Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged 20 space-startup founders to build an “aura” that would draw the world’s talent to India. But that might be a wrong framing married to the old view of space. A private space sector cannot harvest success merely because its wares are called rockets and launch vehicles; the romance that carried the state programme will not carry a business.

A recent peer-reviewed analysis in *Economics Letters* by Alessio Terzi and Francesco Nicoli finds that it cost \$13,302 to loft a kilogram into low-earth orbit on an Indian rocket in 2025 – costlier than China (\$5,809), Japan, Russia, Europe and the United States (\$3,225), and well above the global average of \$3,868. That is because India launches too rarely and uneconomically to rapidly build the required reputation for reliability. There were only five launches in 2025, against the 30 that were projected. The consequence is visible. GSAT-N2, at 4,700 kg too heavy for ISRO’s LVM-3, went up on a Falcon 9; Pixxel and Digan-tara – two of the 20 at Mr. Modi’s meeting – rode SpaceX to orbit. SpaceX alone put three-quarters of the world’s payload into orbit in 2025, underlining its near monopolistic stranglehold but also pointing to opportunities. The value of India’s space sector can no longer rely on aura but in jobs, in long-term capital and the tax revenues that follow and, in heavy-lift launches that undercut SpaceX and China. Moon bases with NASA and interplanetary reveries belong to the new imagination of space, and they matter – but they are the ornament, not the engine.

The debate over transparency in judicial appointments has resurfaced after Justice Ujjal Bhuyan of the Supreme Court of India recently observed that greater openness in the collegium process would strengthen public confidence and help ensure that merit remains the governing principle. Reformers argue that insulation from political interference was never meant to become insulation from constitutional accountability itself – a question that has remained unresolved for three decades.

The collegium is a judicial creation, not a constitutional one. The First Judges Case (1981) gave the executive primacy in appointments; the Second Judges Case (1993 4 SCC 441) shifted primacy to the collectively formed opinion of the Chief Justice of India and senior judges; the Third Judges Case (1998 7 SCC 739) expanded this into today’s five-member collegium. The reasoning was sound, but close to three decades later, the process remains among the least transparent in any major constitutional democracy: no notification of vacancies, no eligibility matrix, no known methodology for assessing candidates. Even Fali Nariman, credited as an architect of the collegium, later turned critic, recalling that it was ‘not receptive at all’ to the Bar. When the system’s own architects concede that it answers to no one, reform can hardly be called intervention.

Resolutions without reasons

One has the example of the collegium’s own record on disclosure, which has moved backwards, not forwards – perhaps the clearest evidence of an institution retreating deeper into opacity. In October 2017, it began publishing resolutions with brief reasons for elevation, a step then hailed as a foundation for transparency.

That practice thinned steadily, and since November 28, 2024, resolutions have stopped naming which members took part in a decision or disclosing any reasoning at all. In November 2025, (then) Chief Justice of India (CJI) B.R. Gavai confirmed that the collegium had resolved to stop publishing detailed reasons altogether, citing concern that disclosure could harm the career prospects of candidates – a rationale that would equally justify withholding reasons from every rejected litigant.

This cannot be seen in isolation: the Court, in the MediaOne judgment (2023), held that sealed-cover secrecy is ‘antithetical to a transparent and accountable system’. If that principle governs the court’s own cases, why should a lesser standard govern its own?

This absence of due process has fuelled a recurring allegation: that opacity has allowed



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The judiciary that demands transparency from every institution of governance cannot ask citizens to trust it on faith alone

relatives of sitting and retired judges – the so-called ‘Uncle Judges’ – an easier passage to the Bench than first-generation lawyers with no lineage to lean on. It is important to remember this is not a complaint from critics from outside alone: former CJI R.M. Lodha himself remarked that nearly one in three High Court judges could be an ‘uncle’.

The allegation is not anecdotal: in 2018, the Union government flagged 11 of the 33 names recommended by the Allahabad High Court collegium, noting that they were relatives of sitting or retired judges. A broader assessment in 2025 found that nearly 30% of the Supreme Court judges – roughly 10 of 33 – had familial links to former judges. In January 2025, this issue pushed the collegium to consider barring judges’ kith and kin from consideration altogether (the proposal was discussed and in principle it was agreed to have higher scrutiny if candidates are relatives, but legally a bar was not created). That, in itself, is an admission that without a publicly defined selection matrix, there is no objective way to distinguish a meritorious relative from a beneficiary of judicial lineage.

This is where the judiciary’s own jurisprudence turns inward. Articles 14 and 16 guarantee equality and equal opportunity in public employment. In *Secretary, State of Karnataka and Others vs Umadevi* (2006 4 SCC 1), the Court held that appointments to public office cannot be made through backdoor methods and must ordinarily follow a transparent procedure open to eligible candidates. If constitutional equality demands openness in the recruitment of a clerk or an engineer, why should the highest constitutional offices remain exempt from comparable standards? To be sure, judicial appointments cannot be reduced to a competitive examination; qualities such as independence and temperament resist quantification. But, qualitative judgment does not require the total absence of procedure. It is prudent to note the irony: the Court itself held, in *CPIO vs Subhash Chandra Agarwal* (2019 3 SCC 1), that the CJI’s office falls within the Right to Information Act – a logic never extended to how judges are appointed.

What other democracies do

Other constitutional democracies show that transparency and judicial independence can coexist. In the United Kingdom, the Judicial Appointments Commission publicly advertises vacancies and conducts structured interviews; in South Africa, the Judicial Service Commission invites nominations publicly and conducts televised interviews. None of these systems is

The limits of air power, implications for theatre-isation

The wars in Ukraine and Iran delivered the same verdict to every air force. Ukraine kept the larger air force at bay, while in Iran, the skies were dominated by the opposing side, yet air superiority still failed to end the war. Both point to the same limitation of air power: it has not grown weaker, but it is no longer sufficient to win a war on its own.

That is the real stake in India’s own debate: its Air Force has long favoured operational flexibility over fixed commands – an approach proven against Pakistan but untested against China.

Air power’s limits exposed

Two wars and one wider pattern illustrate three ways in which air power falls short.

The first is the denial of airspace. What determined control of Ukraine’s skies was not Russia’s aircraft numbers, but Ukraine’s networked air defence. This is what the United States Air Force’s 2025 guidance concedes: contested low-level airspace is a problem that air superiority alone cannot solve. For India, this cuts both ways – integrated air defence could deny China control of the skies, or leave India exposed to the same risk in reverse.

The second is dominance of the air space. The allied air campaign against Iran is the clearest case of dominance without a decisive outcome. The allies had complete control of the skies, yet Tehran held firm. What they could see, they hit; what Iran hid, it survived. That should concern India, because what has worked against Pakistan may not hold against China. Pakistan lacks strategic depth and can be stressed quickly; China, given its military capacity, can absorb losses and continue fighting.

The third is the cost-arithmetic. This structurally favours the weaker force. A Shahed-type drone (Iran) costs roughly \$20,000 to \$50,000, while the interceptors can cost millions. India saw a version of this during Operation Sindoor (May 2025), when Pakistan’s cheaper drones forced the use of costlier



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India’s flexible air strategy faces an uncertain test against China

interceptors. Against China, that arithmetic operates on a much larger scale, and India is not yet prepared for it.

These limits are already forcing a doctrinal rethink across most modern air forces. For India, the challenge is structural: the centralised model of the Indian Air Force (IAF), proven against Pakistan, remains untested against China, where the terrain could compound these limitations.

The IAF’s case against theatre-isation

The IAF favours flexibility over fixed commands. Four tests decide whether that position holds against China too.

The first is the flexibility principle. The IAF’s claim is that what has worked before will work again. Against Pakistan, it did – Balakot (2019) and Sindoor demonstrated that. Against China, however, the numbers are tighter: 460-520 combat aircraft against the People’s Liberation Army Air Force’s roughly 65 squadrons. The mountains make the challenge even greater, with fewer airbases and less room to redeploy. So the flexibility that defines the IAF’s approach may not hold where it matters most.

The second is the integration deficit. If flexibility cannot close the gap, then joint-ness might. Two parts can help bridge this deficit. The first is joint-force generation, which has never been built sufficiently for the China front. The second is peacetime jointness, which requires no new hardware, only training and shared planning. Kargil exposed this gap in 1999; the Ladakh crisis in 2020 showed that it still persisted.

The third is more institutional, than operational. Two aspects matter. The resistance is more about career progression than doctrine. Also, ranks do not map evenly across the three services, leaving joint chains of command unsettled. Neither factor determines whether flexibility or jointness will actually work, although both matter. The United States made joint postings mandatory; not a career risk.

flawless, but each rests on a premise that India has yet to accept: independence is strengthened, not weakened, when citizens understand how judges are chosen.

India’s collegium continues to operate as though it belongs to an earlier era of institutional deference. Political theorist Jürgen Habermas argued that democratic legitimacy ultimately rests on the public sphere – an arena where institutions must justify themselves before informed citizens.

This is not abstract: every judicial appointment is now dissected on social media within minutes. The scrutiny of a CJI’s own remark comparing youngsters to ‘cockroaches’ travelled from placards at Jantar Mantar to trending hashtags within hours; it will not take long for such movements to arrive at the doorstep of the higher judiciary itself. Contempt jurisdiction, built for the newsroom and the courtroom gallery, cannot be used to trifle the scrutiny of this scale and anonymity – it is an alarm bell for a system that still keeps its own appointments behind closed doors and resists constructive criticism. Institutions that embrace reform voluntarily emerge stronger; those that resist witness a slow erosion of the legitimacy they seek to protect.

Reform, not retreat

None of this requires dismantling the collegium; it only requires modernising it. A transparent framework could publish anticipated vacancies in advance, invite applications from eligible advocates, disclose objective eligibility criteria, and record reasoned recommendations explaining why one candidate was preferred over another. Confidential inputs on integrity can remain protected – transparency does not demand disclosure of every file, only openness about the process, the criteria and the reasoning behind constitutional appointments.

This is ultimately not a contest between the judiciary and the executive, nor an attempt to weaken judicial independence. It is a question of whether one constitutional value is allowed to eclipse another. The Constitution promises an independent judiciary, but, equally, promises equality, fairness and reasoned decision-making; values that are complementary, not adversarial. The debate of the 1990s was executive versus judiciary. The debate of this decade is opacity versus transparency. Therefore, unless the collegium accepts that independence without accountability breeds the very distrust it was designed to prevent, this asymmetry between what the judiciary demands of every other institution and what it permits of itself will continue to exist.

The fourth is consultative authority. The IAF’s own proposal – a Joint Coordination Centre – depends on everyone agreeing, and a crisis leaves no time for that. A theatre command puts one person in charge, with the power to act. The U.S., China and Israel have each already made that choice – not proof that it guarantees success, but evidence that a consultative process has its limits.

Of the four questions here, only one concerns how the IAF fights. The rest concern how India organises itself for the next war. That decision lies beyond the IAF; it belongs to India’s political leadership, which has a larger stake in the outcome.

The cost of delay

The IAF’s position is defensible where it has been tested – in Balakot and Sindoor. What it does not tell us is how quickly the force could mobilise or how effectively it could conduct joint operations against China.

The cost of leaving this debate unresolved is real. If, for instance, China moves into Ladakh the same week that Siachen Glacier flares up, someone will have to decide, in real time, which front gets the limited pool of Rafales and S-400 systems.

A jointness gap left unaddressed for another decade could mean that an Integrated Battle Group (IBG) commander along the Line of Actual Control is still planning around air support that may not reliably arrive when needed to defend India’s territorial integrity. And if that were to happen, people would not remember the missing theatre command, but a military that was simply not ready for war.

None of this is a case against the IAF. It is a case against testing the IAF’s convictions in a crisis, when there may be no second chance. Therefore, one could argue that theatre-isation does not dilute the IAF’s flexibility; rather, it is the missing structure that could allow that flexibility to survive contact with the one border crisis India has not faced in many decades.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

New airport, save wetlands

The decision of the Tamil Nadu government, under the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam, to look for a new airport site for Chennai, instead of Parandur, to protect agricultural lands and local livelihoods is a laudable attempt. In general, the State government should give priority to enacting a law for the protection of all identified wetlands, along with an effective policy for

their conservation. Urban land use, including railways, has increased considerably, encroaching mainly on agricultural lands, forests and grasslands. Many wetlands have been lost or impaired through draining, dredging, filling, excavation, construction and pollution. The protection of wetlands by discouraging urban development activities is therefore necessary. We consider everything to be

pervaded by a subtle divine presence, be it water bodies, birds and animals, flora, or the stars and planets. But very little attention is paid to protecting them. Utilising nature’s gifts to mankind without causing harm is the only sensible approach. The conversion of agricultural lands and water bodies has caused considerable suffering.

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Use of term

It is right for women MLAs in Tamil Nadu to demand that the term ‘*Kanni Pechu*’ be dropped, but not

because it is a ‘gendered term that perpetuates patriarchal notions’. Rather, it is an inane Artificial Intelligence translation into

Tamil of the English term ‘maiden speech’. I am sure Tamil experts can vouch that there has never been any patriarchal conspiracy in our history to invoke references to *kannis* or maidens either to belittle women or to demean our representatives in people’s assemblies.

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